

97TH ACADEMY AWARDS

OUR OSCAR PICKS

Who will win and who should win, and is "Anora" the best picture to beat? **Michael Phillips in A+E**



LIFE+TRAVEL

Semicolon survives

After the beloved West Town bookstore's owner announced its closing, she was inundated with support — financial and emotional.

REAL ESTATE

How to sell today

Tips to help you navigate the tricky conditions sellers face in 2025.



Johnson's upcoming testimony fraught

Mayor to face Congress in an arena of political risk — and theater

By Alice Yin and Daniel C. Vock
Chicago Tribune

When Mayor Brandon Johnson lands in the nation's capital this week to testify at a Republican-led hearing on sanctuary cities, he will be walking into one of the riskiest arenas of his political career.

On Wednesday, the U.S. House Oversight and Government Reform Committee will put Johnson and three other Democratic mayors in the hot seat, where GOP members will try to score political points off them over their respective laws blocking local police from assisting in immigration enforcement.

It will be the first time a sitting Chicago mayor testifies before Congress since Richard M. Daley. Johnson will be in a high-pressure spot as he faces questioning from Republican congressmen eager to curry favor with President Donald Trump, who has made his disdain for Chicago and other sanctuary cities a central plank of his administration.

Underscoring the made-for-TV feel of the event, the Oversight panel released a video trailer last week featuring a clip of committee Chair Rep. James Comer declaring, "(If) they're going to continue to disobey the law, then I think we should cut as much of their federal funding as we can cut."

The dark teaser cycles through a cacophony of headlines about migrants accused of crimes in the four cities before blasting in a giant font: "GAME ON!"

And looming over the political theater Wednesday will be the Department of Justice's ongoing lawsuit against Chicago over that same sanctuary policy, adding an extra layer of peril to Johnson's

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A NATURAL DISASTER

Midwest communities worry that firings of parks and forest employees will harm ecosystems, economies and education



Above: The workers' main gate frames the Administration Building at Pullman National Historical Park in Chicago's Pullman neighborhood. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

At top: Eric Anderson was fired from his position as biological science technician and lead fire effects monitor at Indiana Dunes National Park. **E.JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Adriana Pérez | Chicago Tribune

At the southern tip of Lake Michigan, an hour's drive from Chicago, lies one of the country's most biodiverse national parks. Shoreline birds build their homes along the coastal habitat. Prairie grass, woodlands and wetlands reminiscent of the Everglades fringe the trails that lace through Indiana Dunes National Park.

Each year millions of people marvel at this pocket of natural beauty sandwiched between a stretch of steel plants — almost 3 million visitors generated \$206 million in revenue for local communities in 2023 — but the efforts required to maintain the delicate balance of such varied ecosystems often occur behind the scenes and are far from glamorous.

Eric Anderson managed wildfire risks and restored habitat through controlled burns in the 15,000-acre park, which relies on fire to thrive and sprawls close to urban residential areas.

"The people doing this kind of work tend to do this because they love it," said Anderson, who left a higher-paying job in corporate consulting to pursue the National Park Service's mission: to preserve natural resources for future generations.

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INSIDE

From Croatia, with dreams of the NBA

Illinois' Tomislav Ivišić, left, and his twin, Zvonimir, have eyes on the NBA — but first comes making an impact in March. **Chicago Sports**

Europe's effort to sway Trump fails

Blowup in the Oval Office with Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelenskyy caps a tortured week of allies' overtures. **Nation & World**



APPHOTOS

Rooted in faith, Guatemalans defy deportation fears

Community flourishes as its roots in Chicago grow deeper each year

By Laura Rodríguez Presa
Chicago Tribune

On the Southwest Side of Chicago, a Catholic church service was being held in K'iche', a Mayan language, and Olga held her daughter, who is 2 years old and 9 months, as they prayed. Both wore a picturesque and handwoven *traje*, or a traditional outfit from the highlands of Coban, Alta Vera Paz in Central Guatemala.

Her young daughter and her family in Guatemala, she said, are her inspiration to stay resilient amid the newfound turmoil that immigrants, particularly those who are in the U.S. without permanent legal status, face under the administration of President Donald Trump, she said.

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Valentina Xol, 2, plays with her father, Fernando Pec, during a church service for Guatemalan migrants conducted in a native language on the Southwest Side on Feb. 23. Valentina's mother, Olga Cuz, is at right. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**